

Cervical Cancer

Protect yourself: Know the facts

What is cervical cancer?

Cervical cancer is when abnormal cells begin to develop and if not removed can become cancer.

What are the symptoms?

Early stages of cervical cancer usually have no symptoms. When the cancer is more advanced, the most common symptom is abnormal bleeding from the vagina.



What is screening?

Screening means looking for signs of disease before symptoms appear. Cervical Cancer screenings look for signs of disease before symptoms begin.

Healthcare providers screen using a Pap test, also called a Pap smear and an HPV test. These tests only take a few seconds and are usually painless. During these tests, a health care provider collects cells from the cervix.

An HPV test checks for high-risk types of the human papillomavirus (HPV) which can cause cancer. A Pap test can find abnormal cells, which means it can find cells that are not normal when it is easier to treat.

Cervical cancer is almost 100 percent curable when found early.

When should I be screened?

age

21

Women should begin having Pap tests every 3 years.

age

30

Women should get a Pap test every 3 years and an HPV test every 5 years OR a Pap test and HPV test every 5 years.

age

65

Women should talk with their doctor about when to stop screening.

How can I help prevent cervical cancer?



Don't smoke. Smoking nearly doubles your chance of getting cervical cancer compared to nonsmokers.



Vaccinate against the HPV (human papillomavirus) between the ages of 9 - 26.



Limit number of sexual partners and use condoms to reduce chances of getting HPV and other sexually transmitted diseases.



Have regular Pap tests as recommended.

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When should I get the HPV vaccine?

The HPV vaccine can help prevent HPV infection which can lead to 6 different types of cancer in men and women. Women who get the vaccine should continue having regular Pap tests.

Before 15th birthday (can start at age 9)



After 15th birthday



Ages 26+ should talk with their doctor to determine if the vaccine is right for them.

What if I can't afford the tests?

- Most cancer screenings are covered by insurance, Medicare, and Medicaid.
- Most insurance plans also cover HPV vaccinations for females and males ages 11-26.
- If you do not have insurance, the Kentucky Women's Cancer Screening Program (KWCS) may help. **Call the KWCS at 844-249-0708.**

For additional information:



Visit **www.kycancerprogram.org** and click on the Pathfinder link to find cancer support services and programs near you or to connect with your local Regional Cancer Control Specialist.

National Cancer Institute

1-800-4-CANCER, www.cancer.gov

American Cancer Society

1-800-ACS-2345, www.cancer.org

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention

www.cdc.gov